

Abroad in Madrid: A Global Perspective

My first experience traveling overseas was informed by my knowledge of globalization and interdisciplinary frameworks, as well as a cultivated interest in global cultures, structures, and challenges. While the focus of my academic background lies in the functions of international institutions and governance frameworks, I have long held an immense interest in cultural analysis. I have connected to this process due to what cultural elements communicate about a society and their role in a greater global context. For this reason, the aspects of experience I connected most with during my time abroad are rooted in the cultural differences between Spain and the US, between European cities I visited and the American cities I have been familiar with throughout my life.

Growing up in St. Louis, Missouri, I was always curious about the wider world. St. Louis is not a particularly small city, but it tends to feel like one. Few people who are born there seem to leave; they attend a school in-state and settle down in an area within twenty miles of their childhood home. If you meet people from around St. Louis as an adult, there's over a 90 percent chance that one of their first questions will be "What high school did you go to?" Through years of school, if my dad asked the last name of a classmate I mentioned in passing, odds were that he had gone to school with their parents and remembered them from "back in the day." Over time, something about the familiarity of the city began to bother me. New generations took the place of old ones, but nothing else ever seemed to change. The world always seemed too big to just stay in one spot, but that's what most of the people around me had done. As I got older, it became increasingly clear that if I wanted a different experience, I would have to forge the path myself.

Before traveling to Spain, I had never been overseas. My knowledge of the country was limited, but it felt like a place I could connect to. The immense history, plethora of museums, and promise of fresh regional cuisine were key deciding factors, along with the six years of Spanish classes I had taken in school. Unfortunately, most of my Spanish language skills were acquired based on Mexican Spanish; Spain Spanish is another beast entirely. Between the nation's distinct accent, regional lingo, and use of the *vosotros* verb tense, it was a bit disheartening to realize how little I could communicate at first. However, I took the barrier as an opportunity for growth, and resolved to practice my Spanish whenever I could. Besides, the initial disappointment of my lapse in preparedness was buffered by the other factors, which exceeded my expectations. My eagerness to explore ultimately motivated me to gain more from the experience, a phenomenon backed by findings that learning motivations impact behavior in educational travel; "...when learners are exposed to and interact with different cultures, they tend to engage more, and this increases their passion to learn. Educational travel can arouse the desire to learn, which influences a learner's intrinsic motivation and capacity for autonomy in learning" (Chau & Ren, 2024).

Madrid's museums played a key role in this intrinsically motivated education. I visited the Golden Triangle of art museums, the National Archeological Museum, and the Royal Collections Gallery, among others. Although the Prado is perhaps the most famous of these institutions, each exhibit I visited had a unique perspective and undeniable merit. I was fascinated by the overt political nature of many Spanish works; Picasso's famous pieces that highlighted the terror of the Spanish Civil War, Goya's Black Paintings, which were influenced by his earlier works on the Peninsular War, and the various religious depictions and royal portraits that can be found in most of the city's older collections. Art and media have always

fascinated me as lenses through which to view the world, and as mechanisms of resistance. People often doubt the true power of artists, claiming that change is only made possible through politicians or martyrs. Standing in some of Spain's oldest museums, surrounded by paintings much older and larger than I, the true power of artistic expression was undeniable. Although I had seen some of the more famous works before, in books or pictures online, there was something incredibly more intense about sharing a room with them. Many pieces that I saw were multiple centuries old, having been created in a world that seems to no longer exist. The more time I spent with this art, whether the work was 100 or 1,000 years old, the clearer it became that their world was mine.

While the ancient sculptures and Renaissance paintings draw the most crowds for obvious reasons, I found the most impactful art to be that which engaged with non-hegemonic narratives. The National Library of Spain held a temporary exhibition in early autumn called "Pinacoteca Migrante," or "Migrant Art Gallery." Colonialism played a huge role in the construction of the Spanish state, and Peruvian artist Sandra Gamarra interrogates this history of racism and extractivism through a multimedia approach. Paintings, depicting what colonial narratives have described as untouched New World landscapes, are overlaid with written passages that illuminate the harmful construction and domination of false discourse around Spanish colonialism. These themes are expanded throughout the gallery to include other forms of oppression, with one piece drawing a parallel between the treatment of trans bodies and Palestinian refugees. A key component of art's importance lies in its ability to communicate what seems incommunicable, to make others see what is all too often unseen. This is described as Holm and Tilley as the process of documentation, or "how an artwork can make visible that which is otherwise overlooked, obscured, or difficult to perceive." In the aesthetics of creative

activism, art is promoted as a tool of recognition, which the authors refer to as the ability of creative works to “enhance empathy, build connections across difference, and provide a means to link diverse peoples and build peace through intercultural connection and understanding” (Holm & Tilley, 2023). This reveals the unique capability of artistic media to restructure mental processes and reintegrate them with emotional logic.

It is heartening to see counterhegemonic discourse in public spaces, and this is something I truly appreciate about Spanish culture. Counterhegemonic ideas are “distinguished by their questioning of political orthodoxies. They ‘stem from and facilitate visions of alternative, more just futures’ and their circulation involves the ‘resistances, disruptions and alternative pathways used in activism for policy reform by people in disparate locations’” (Cloutier et al., 2025). Although inequalities remain, Madrid is progressive in terms of its level of visibility for resistance. Throughout the city, I observed this in many forms, including pro-Palestine and anti-war graffiti, LGBTQ+ flags hung from residential balconies, and regular protests opposing gentrification, government corruption, and the ongoing Israeli occupation. One of my courses while studying in Madrid centered around media, gender, and identity, and included in the curriculum class outings to practice “reading the city.” Early on, our professor introduced the concept of a city as a form of media. They encouraged us to notice how people dressed and carried themselves, which areas appeared to have an abundance or lack of diversity, and the subtle forms of resistance that are expressed on the streets every day.

In viewing the city itself as a form of media, I gained a deeper understanding of Madrid and reflected more on what I could learn through simple observation. In focusing increased attention on the details of this foreign culture, I inevitably gained a new perspective regarding my own. Among the most striking differences I recognized in Spain were the levels of

collectivism and femininity as defined by Hofstede's cultural comparison model. This framework defines culture as "the collective programming of the mind that distinguishes the members of one group of category of people from others" (Hofstede 2011). While the framework is by no means comprehensive, it provides a useful tool in comparing the qualities of one country to another.

Spanish collectivism is rooted in the values of its Roman and Islamic settlers. Today, Spain consists of 17 autonomous communities, the strong regional bonds of which have reinforced this collectivism. I have also heard Spaniards claim that the value further solidified in the wake of the Spanish Civil War, as resistance groups came together to rebel against Nationalist oppression. Another dimension of Spanish culture is defined by femininity, which in Hofstede's analysis refers to principles of work-life balance, social support, and cooperation. These values of community are integrated into social, as well as political, aspects of life in Spain. One way in which the public good is prioritized over individual actions lies in the state's environmental practices. Policies not only aim to protect the domestic environment, but are part of larger systems of regulation established by the EU. Upon arriving in Spain, my program orientation coordinator informed us of what is typically a learning curve for American students: "We recycle here." Recycling regulations are expected to be consistently observed, and the nation also maintains laws that outline recycling targets and plastic packaging taxes for corporations. There are five main types of recycling bins, each with a different color lid which corresponds to the materials disposed inside: yellow bins for plastic packaging and metal cans, blue bins for paper products, green bins for glass bottles and containers, and black or gray for general non-recyclable waste. New regulations were implemented in January 2025 to increase Spain's alignment with the 2020 EU Circular Economy Action Plan (European Environment Agency 2025).

Furthermore, quality of life is valued above nearly all else, something I found most evident in the laid-back tradition of siesta and the Spanish penchant for frequent, social dining experiences that often last for hours. Socializing often extends long past the dinner hours, and going to bars or nightclubs several times a week is a common occurrence. Nightclub experiences provided an opportunity to interact with people from all over the world; some of them American, most of them Spanish, Italian, Dutch, or British. Everyone had a different reason for their travel, and the vast majority spoke English. One night in Portugal, I joked with someone from the Netherlands about the bad rep Americans tend to suffer from, sometimes rightfully so. I asked what they perceived to be the most off-putting qualities and received an answer of three characteristics: they lack open-mindedness, they are always the loudest people in the room, and they talk about themselves more than they ask questions. In my opinion, the merits of these arguments vary based on context, but still, I was amazed at the clarity of the response. This question was one I always wondered about, and rather than being offended, which seemed within my right, I was fascinated by the cultural nuance of the conversation and its larger context.

My experience abroad has not only influenced my perception of the world, but also my perception of myself. In three months, I traveled to Spain, Portugal, and Italy, visiting seven cities between these locations and traveling more widely than I had in my previous 21 years of life. I am more independent, open-minded, adaptable, and resilient than I ever realized. I learned to find opportunity in uncertainty and connected to myself through the active shaping of my own experience. Before going abroad, I never would have thought of myself as someone who would take a weekend trip to a foreign country with virtual strangers or stay out dancing at a club until 6:00 am. I didn't expect to find such peace in exploring a big city by myself or aimlessly wandering foreign neighborhoods. These few months in Spain have reinforced a confidence

within myself that I will always rise to the occasion; all I have to do is provide myself the opportunity.

Further than personal growth, studying abroad has instilled traits that will contribute to my professional growth. In a globalized world, it is increasingly essential to embody the qualities of a global citizen in all areas of life. Not only are these characteristics traits that I spent months cultivating in Madrid, but they are values I will hold throughout my career. I am passionate about empowering and amplifying non-hegemonic viewpoints, and engaging with these while abroad has strengthened my understanding of intersectionality and cultural nuance. Moreover, it proved to me firsthand that the global issues I have been studying are not just concepts, but the lived realities of people across the world.

References

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